R. PRAGGNANANDHAA, 19
VAISHALI RAMESHBABU, 23
Grandmasters



She thinks he's "messy"; he thinks she does "things perfectly", which can at times be "annoying". What binds them is their unbridled love for chess. Four years her junior, Pragg took to the game only after watching big sister Vaishali play it. The duo became the first siblings to attain the Grandmaster tag and qualify for the prestigious Candidates tournament. While father Rameshbabu manages their media engagements and playing calendar, mother Nagalakshmi is a constant presence by their side at key tournaments. Says Pragg, "There were many difficult moments financially but we never felt the pinch because they never told us about it. They have motivated us and kept us going during tough tournaments. They have been very important in our journey."

Comedians Over the Board, in 2022. In March 2023, Raina would play Gukesh and lose after being in a winning position. The seven-minute video streamed on ChessBase India's YouTube channel has thus far netted 7.3 million views. Samay's chatty style and humorous commentary has gone a long way in changing the perception of chess being a game for nerds. Or as Anand, showing his funny side, told Samay: "You've turned chess into a joke."

The chess fraternity acknowledges the impact of online creators like Samay and Biswa Kalyan. The latter even co-directed the documentary, *Candidates*, on India's chess prodigies, which will release in 2025. "The difficult part about chess was that it was conceived as a hard, intimidating game. We had to take down that glass barrier," says known chess commentator and IM Tania Sachdev who was part of the Olympiad gold-winning team. "Getting a non-professional chess player voice like that of Samay into the scene really exponentially grew the game. The audience could relate to the game, have fun with it." Sachdev and Anand also lauded the efforts of Sagar Shah and ChessBase India which "opened up the game to audiences". Starting in 2015, Sagar began covering the chess scene in India, interviewing its youngest and most talented practitioners as well as providing technical material for chess enthusiasts to hone their skills.

More recently, both Samay and Sagar were at the centre of the first ever screening-cum-livestreaming of the 14 games of the World Chess Championships, held at The Habitat in Mumbai. Partnering with chess.com, it had Anand and comedians like Samay, Bhatt and others joining Sagar and Tania Sachdev giving commentary through the long games. "In chess, visuals don't do the talking," says Sachdev, who is backed by Red Bull. "You have to make chess accessible and entertaining while being true to it. You cannot make viewers feel like *yeh kya ho raha hai*."

What it takes to be a Grandmaster

- **Calculation and intuition: A deep understanding of the game and ability to foresee your opponent's moves**
- **Concentration: The ability to focus for hours on end as the pressure builds up with every move**
- **Mental resilience: Playing at a high level consistently requires focusing all your mental energy on the board**
- **Confidence: The supreme will to win**